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ARTICLE

Easter Crowds Are Coming - But America's Christian Worldview Is Collapsing

BY PNW STAFF APRIL 02, 2026

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This Easter weekend, sanctuaries across America will be packed.

Parking lots will overflow. Extra chairs will be unfolded. Families dressed in spring colors will fill pews, sing "Christ the Lord Is Risen Today," and hear once again the greatest announcement in human history: Jesus Christ is alive.

And in one sense, that is deeply encouraging.

Pastors are expecting one of their biggest crowds of the year, just as they have for years. More than half of U.S. Protestant pastors say Easter is their church's highest-attendance Sunday, and for many others it ranks second or third--alongside Christmas and Mother's Day. In other words, if there is one Sunday Americans still instinctively know matters, it is Easter.

Even better, the doctrine at the center of Easter is still surprisingly strong in the public imagination. Recent State of Theology findings show that roughly two-thirds of U.S. adults agree that the biblical accounts of Jesus' bodily resurrection are accurate, and among those who attend church at least once or twice a month, belief rises to around 90%.

That is the good news.

Now for the bad news.

A new 2026 worldview study from the Cultural Research Center at Arizona Christian University found that only 4% of American adults possess a biblical worldview--a number unchanged from 2023 and lower than 2020. Even more sobering, overwhelming majorities of Americans lack biblical alignment in core areas such as truth, morality, salvation, relationships, and faith practices.

That means millions of Americans may sincerely say, "Yes, I believe Jesus rose from the dead," while living Monday through Saturday as though His resurrection has little authority over their money, sexuality, relationships, priorities, convictions, entertainment, or identity.

That is the contradiction.

And it may be one of the defining spiritual crises of our age.

**America Has Not Entirely Rejected Christianity--It Has Diluted It**

For years, many believers assumed the greatest threat to the church would be outright atheism.

But the greater danger may be something far more deceptive: a half-Christianity that keeps the symbols of the faith while quietly surrendering its substance.

America still likes Jesus at a distance. We like Him inspirational, seasonal, and ceremonial. We like Him in stained glass, in family traditions, in sentimental Easter language, and in vague affirmations about hope and love.

What many do not want is the risen Christ with absolute authority.

Because the resurrection is not merely a comforting church doctrine. It is a declaration of kingship. It means Jesus is not just Savior in theory--He is Lord in practice.

And that is where much of modern Christianity collapses.

A person can say "He is risen" on Sunday and still live by self on Monday.

A church can preach orthodox doctrine and still produce disciples who are being shaped more by TikTok, Netflix, politics, celebrity culture, and therapeutic self-worship than by Scripture.

That is not resurrection power. That is religious familiarity without spiritual transformation.

**So Why Is This Happening? Here Are 5 Major Reasons**

**1. Many people have inherited Christian language without experiencing Christian conversion**

One of the biggest reasons for the disconnect is that many Americans know the vocabulary of Christianity but have never truly been changed by the power of the gospel.

They know words like grace, faith, cross, resurrection, blessing, and forgiveness. They may even agree with key doctrines. But agreement is not the same as regeneration.

The New Testament never teaches that merely affirming true facts about Jesus saves a person. Even demons know who Jesus is.

The question is not only, "Do you believe Jesus rose?"

The deeper question i

Many in church today have had exposure to Christianity, but not surrender to Christ. They have been near the truth without being transformed by it.

That creates a generation of people who can pass a theology quiz on Easter Sunday but still build their lives on the exact same values as the world.

And if the gospel has not changed your desires, your loves, your habits, and your obedience, then what you have may be religion, but it is not biblical discipleship.

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**2. The modern church has often prioritized decisions over discipleship**

For decades, much of American church culture has been very effective at getting people to respond emotionally--but far less effective at teaching them to walk faithfully.

It is easier to count raised hands than to build mature Christians.

It is easier to fill a room than to form a worldview.

It is easier to create a moving Easter service than to cultivate people who actually think biblically about marriage, truth, suffering, holiness, repentance, and obedience.

And that is part of the crisis exposed by today's data.

According to recent worldview research, even many professing Christians remain deeply confused on foundational matters such as moral truth, salvation, the nature of God, and human identity. That confusion does not happen overnight. It happens when churches become event-driven but not formation-driven.

In other words, we have not only had a culture problem. We have had a discipleship deficit.

The church in many places has taught people how to attend, how to feel inspired, and how to identify as Christian.

But many have never been deeply taught how to deny themselves, take up their cross, renew their minds, and live under the authority of Scripture.

That is why someone can attend Easter every year and still have a worldview that looks almost indistinguishable from secular culture.

**3. Christians are being catechized by the world six days a week**

Another reason for th

The culture is discipli

For one hour on Sunday, many hear a sermon.

Then for the next six days, they are immersed in a nonstop stream of messages telling them:

truth is personal,
feelings are authority,
identity is self-created,
sex is sacred but covenant is optional,
comfort is the highest good,
and morality is whatever avoids social backlash.

That is catechism too.

And it is working.

Barna's worldview findings have repeatedly shown that Americans increasingly blend pieces of Christianity with competing belief systems--a kind of spiritual syncretism where Jesus is kept, but His authority is edited.

That is why so many people can sincerely say, "I believe in the resurrection," while also embracing ideas that directly contradict Scripture.

They do not see the contradiction because they have absorbed a hybrid faith: biblical language on top, secular assumptions underneath.

And if believers are not daily in the Word, in prayer, in Christian community, and under sound teaching, the culture will shape them by default.

Nobody drifts into holiness.

**4. Many people want the benefits of Christianity without the cost of lordship**

This may be the hardest truth of all.

A lot of people want comfort, hope, forgiveness, community, heaven, and Easter joy.

They just do not want repentance.

They want a Savior who removes guilt, but not a Lord who demands surrender.

They want resurrection as inspiration, but not as interruption.

Because if Jesus truly rose from the dead, then He has the right to tell us what to do with our bodies, our money, our relationships, our politics, our desires, our homes, our parenting, and our futures.

That is where cultural Christianity begins to crack.

People will often acce

And this helps explair uth. Some still operate as though being a "good person" is what ultimately makes them right with God, despite the gospel's clear declaration that salvation is through Christ, not self-improvement.

That is not a small error. It is the difference between religion and redemption.

**5. Easter attendance can expose affection for tradition more than devotion to Christ**

Easter crowds are real. But large attendance does not automatically mean deep allegiance.

For many, Easter remains one of the few moments where Christianity still feels culturally expected, emotionally familiar, and socially beautiful.

There is nothing wrong with that in itself. In fact, it may be one of the last open doors many people still have to hear the gospel.

But we should not confuse attendance with awakening.

A full church does not necessarily mean a spiritually healthy church.

A crowded sanctuary does not necessarily mean a surrendered people.

And hearing the resurrection story is not the same as living in resurrection power.

That is why this Easter should not merely be a celebration of turnout. It should be a moment of reckoning.

Because the church does not just need more people in the room.

The church needs more people who actually belong to Jesus.

**The Resurrection Was Never Meant to Be Merely Believed--It Was Meant to Change Everything**

This is where Easter becomes deeply personal.

The resurrection is not just proof that Christianity is true.
It is proof that Jesus Christ is alive now--and that every part of life must bow before Him.

If He rose, then truth is not flexible.
If He rose, then sin is not harmless.
If He rose, then repentance is not optional.
If He rose, then holiness is not legalism.
If He rose, then church cannot just be a seasonal ritual.
If He rose, then Christianity cannot be reduced to family tradition and positive vibes.

And perhaps that is the word many in the American church most need to hear this Easter:

You can be near the empty tomb and still far from the risen Christ.

That is the tragedy.

But it does not have to stay that way.

This Easter, churches may indeed be full.

The greater question is whether hearts will be surrendered.

Because the true miracle of Easter is not merely that people still show up to hear about the resurrection.

It is that the same risen Savior still has power--right now--to raise spiritually dead people to life.

And America does no

It needs resurrected Christians.

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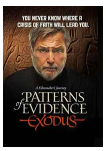


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